



Licence to LOOT

The arrest of MCI President Ketan Desai on charges of corruption and bribery raises questions about the council's procedures and ethical standards

By Mihir Srivastava
and Uday Mahurkar

For a man with a weakness for the good things in life, Ketan Desai had what seemed like the perfect job. He was the president of the Medical Council of India (MCI), a job which gave him a modest salary but plenty of opportunity, and Desai never let even one slip past. Last week, he was arrested by the CBI for allegedly taking Rs 2 crore as bribe for granting recognition to a Punjab-based medical college. Investigators have reasons to believe this is just the tip of the iceberg. The agency has since conducted raids at

several places in Delhi, Punjab, Mumbai and Ahmedabad, Desai's hometown, and has unearthed many of his land deals and investments. Desai and his close family members allegedly own 10 houses, two commercial properties in Andheri, Mumbai, gold worth Rs 39 lakh and his cumulative bank balance runs into Rs 1.08 crore in 13 different accounts at one branch of the Bank of Baroda in Ahmedabad. All of these add up to a booty far beyond Desai's known sources of income. The CBI expects more to come out in a few days, as Desai, they say, is now talking.

The CBI has seized several documents pertaining to Desai's one-stop

shop for all clearances pertaining to medical colleges, be it granting them accreditation or permission to increase the annual student intake. The MCI gives clearances on 14 matters ranging from running of government and private medical colleges and hospitals to establishing uniform standards of higher qualifications in medicine and recognition of medical qualifications in India and abroad. The CBI will now examine 30 to 35 medical institutes that got recognition in the recent past. "Desai ran the MCI like a cartel," says a CBI insider.

This is how Desai operated: the MCI inspection team would visit colleges seeking recognition, file an